



Workshop Art of Illusion

Rossi Fernandes

Computer graphics work has taken off in India, and in large numbers with institutes focussing on 3D modelling mushrooming. 3D modelling, and computer graphics software in general are expensive, but there are plenty of free open-source programs available that anyone can download from the internet.

One such program is Art of Illusion. It's a free download from www.artofillusion.org. It runs on Java and you can use it on almost all operating systems with Java 1.4 or higher installed.

The first glimpse

Art of Illusion isn't the best looking or even the most complex 3D modelling software around. The interface is similar to MS Paint, but the basic structure is like any other 3D modelling software.

The toolbar on the left has tools to create objects. The four windows in the centre are used to view the object from different angles. The pane on the right contains a list of all the objects created and Properties for the object currently selected. The pane at the bottom has the timeline for all the objects. This is used when animating objects in a scene.

Navigating around the screen

The four views show the object or the scene you create from four angles. Each of these views can be changed by clicking on the drop-down menu on the top-left of each view, and then selecting the view you want from the list. It's a good idea to have a front, side and top view setup on three of the views. The last one should be a free-perspective view where the camera can be moved in any direction. You would normally use this view to render a scene.

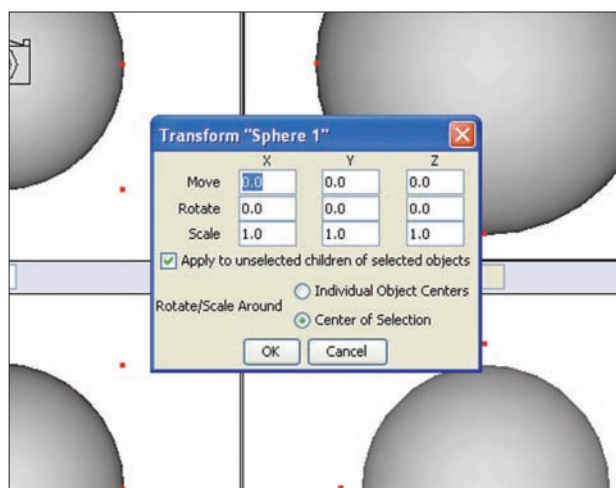
To pan the scene around, right-click and move the mouse. This moves the camera within two dimensions. Use the scroll to zoom in and out of the scene. Holding down the middle-click and moving the mouse will rotate the object in the centre. Left-clicking on an object just moves it around.

If you want to use a reference image in the background as a blueprint, then go to Scene > Set Template Image. Click on Browse, and select the file you want and click on Open.

Free and simple: Art of Illusion is the ideal tool to start your training in 3D modelling

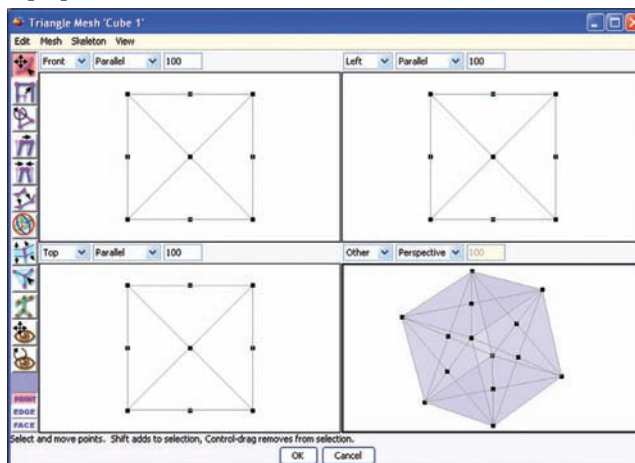
Creating primitives

Primitives are the basic objects that you can create. These objects can then either be modified to form a new object, or a completely new object can be created from scratch. To create a primitive, click on the icon on the left toolbar and click on the viewport in which you want to create the object. You can also create a primitive by clicking on the Object menu and then Create Primitive and then the object of your choice.



Using the Transform feature to adjust object properties

All the created objects will show up on the right pane. These can be selected by clicking on the names. They can be moved using the mouse and the keyboard. The directional keys by themselves can move the object about. Holding the Control key along with the direction keys rotates the object. The object properties listed below also allows you to accurately position the object in the scene. Co-ordinates and angles must be keyed into the object properties area.



Switching to the Edit mode to modify the model